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DEALMAKERS: Musharraf performing a ritual in Mecca, (below) Bhutto her stance after the surge of anti-Musharraf wave for his rebuffed attempts to sack the chief justice of the country. Former prime minister and her erstwhile rival Nawaz Sharif condemned Bhutto for "open betrayal" of the Charter of Democracy that they had signed earlier this year.

According to sources, a deal between Musharraf and Bhutto is almost fixed though no official announcement of it is forthcoming. The basic premise of it involves PPP accepting Musharraf's continuation as President in return for major power sharing in the government after the elections by February next year as well as concessions for Bhutto herself. The Government has already affected a go-slow on corruption cases against the PPP leader and even released some of her seized bank accounts. Publicly the PPP is sticking to its stand that it will not accept Musharraf in uniform but this is a nuanced opposition. For its part, the Government is ruling out changing the law enacted by Musharraf disallowing a third term for Bhutto or Sharif before the presidential elections. Sources indicate that Bhutto had almost accepted not standing for premiership in the elections but increased her demands once Musharraf stumbled after the chief justice fiasco. "What remains, things like whether Musharraf takes off his uniform before his own re-election or after, or who becomes an interim prime minister during the elections, are just the nitty-gritties," points out Zaffar Abbas, resident editor of *Dawn* in Islamabad.

There is much speculation about the contours of the deal. One likely scenario is that the PPP may abstain during the presidential elections in September or October, which Musharraf is expected to contest in uniform. Despite the threats of the Opposition to resign, PPP's abstention coupled with the majority of the ruling PML-Q and its allies would result in an easy victory for the General. He would then step down as

head of the army allowing the PPP to claim a moral victory. Another possibility is that Bhutto will nominate an interim parliamentary leader after the general elections who would ensure that the law is changed to allow herself to be elected to the National Assembly and subsequently as premier.

Of course, all potential deals and speculations depend on PPP actually securing a majority in the elections. Most analysts predict the party to do well in fair elections. However, the perception of a deal may also damage PPP votebank and bitter rivals such as Sharif, Jamaat-e-Islami's Qazi Hussain Ahmed and Imran Khan may provide stiff competition, especially in populous Punjab, if they are able to project the deal as pro-American. Some analysts are also pointing to the danger of polarising society on the basis of secular or liberal versus religious or conservative forces. Such a polarisation may push many

moderates into the hardliners' camp.

What is also not factored in a deal is the possible role of a resurgent Supreme Court. Hussain has already brought a constitutional case against Musharraf retaining the post of army chief and contesting elections before a constitutionally mandated period of

two years after retirement. The Government is trying to mend strained relations with the judiciary through interlocutors such as former premier Zafarullah Jamali. "We had family ties," President Musharraf said when asked about his relations with Chief Justice Iftikhar Chaudhry at a recent function, "and hope to maintain the same harmonious ties in the future." He also added that the "independence of the judiciary is essential for the running of a government".

Many also doubt the sustainability of a power-sharing deal between General Musharraf and Bhutto. Both have strong egos and are likely to resent any curbs on their powers. For Musharraf at least, that is, however, a concern for next year. Bhutto's risk may be more immediate. ■

Given their egos,
doubts persist
over the
sustainability of a
deal between
Bhutto and
Musharraf.